

GRADE 7 · READING LITERATURE · RL.7.9

Fiction vs. History

Compare a fictional story and a historical account of the 1960 Greensboro sit-ins, identifying what the author kept accurate, what was altered, and why those choices affect meaning.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.7.9: Compare a fictional story and a historical account of the 1960 Greensb...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Historical fiction blends real events with invented characters and details. Authors often keep the broader facts (dates, outcomes, key events) accurate while inventing personal details (a character's private thoughts, an imagined conversation) to help readers connect emotionally with history.

Modeled Example

A historical fiction story about the Titanic invents a friendship between two passengers who never actually met. Why might an author do this?

To give readers a personal, emotional entry point into a large historical event, making the scale of the disaster feel individual and relatable.

If a historical account states a battle "lasted three days" and a novel about it says "the fighting seemed endless," is the novel wrong?

Not necessarily wrong — it is using figurative, emotional language to convey a character's experience, while the historical account uses precise, factual language.

The Counter (historical fiction)

1. Etta had walked past the Woolworth's lunch counter every day on her way to the library for two years without once considering sitting down at it. On the first of February, she did.
2. She was not one of the four young men everyone would later talk about — the ones from the college a few blocks over, who had planned it, who had worn their good clothes for it. Etta was fifteen, and she had simply seen them sitting there through the window and, without deciding to, walked in and sat two stools away.
3. The woman behind the counter looked at her for a long moment, then at the four young men, then went back to wiping a spot on the counter that did not need wiping.
4. Etta had expected to feel brave. Instead she felt her hands shaking, and she pressed them flat against her knees under the counter so no one could see.
5. Nobody served them that day. Nobody served them the second day, either, when Etta came back, or the days after that, when the four students returned with more students each morning, filling nearly every stool.
6. Etta's mother found out on the third day, from a neighbor, and was furious in the specific way mothers are furious when they are actually afraid. "You could have told me," she said. Etta said she

The Counter (historical fiction), continued

7. By the end of the month, the sit-ins had spread to other cities. Etta did not know, sitting at that counter in February, that any of that would happen. She only knew that she had walked past the counter for two years, and on that particular day, she had stopped walking past it.

The Greensboro Sit-In

On February 1, 1960, four Black college students — Ezell Blair Jr., Franklin McCain, Joseph McNeil, and David Richmond, all freshmen at North Carolina Agricultural and Technical State University — sat down at the whites-only lunch counter at the F.W. Woolworth store in Greensboro, North Carolina. They ordered coffee and were refused service, but they remained seated until the store closed.

The four students returned the next day with more classmates. By February 5, roughly three hundred students were participating, filling nearly every seat at the lunch counter and spilling into the aisles. The protest was part of a broader sit-in movement that spread rapidly: within two months, similar sit-ins had occurred in over fifty cities across the American South.

The Greensboro sit-ins did not end segregation immediately. Woolworth's lunch counter was not formally desegregated until July 25, 1960, nearly six months after the initial protest, following months of continued demonstrations and a decline in the store's sales. The event is widely credited with helping to launch a wave of student-led nonviolent direct action across the country, contributing to the broader civil rights movement of the 1960s.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit historical fact does the historical account give that the fictional story does not?
2. Why might the author of the fiction story choose not to name the four real students?

Guided Practice

3. What invented character does the fiction add that does not appear in the historical account?

4. Why might the author invent a character like Etta rather than only writing about the four real students?

Guided Practice

5. Does the historical account state how many days passed before the lunch counter was desegregated?

What is the number?

6. How does the fiction story handle that same span of time?

Partner Discussion

7. Why might the fiction story end earlier than the full historical timeline?

8. What explicit number does the historical account give for participants by February 5?

Partner Discussion

9. How does the fiction story represent that same growth in participation, using different, less precise language?

Independent Practice

10. Is Etta's mother's reaction in paragraph 6 something the historical account confirms happened to any real participant? Explain.

11. Why is it reasonable for the fiction to invent a detail like a parent's reaction, even though it is not confirmed by the historical record?

Independent Practice

12. What historical detail about the protest's spread does the historical account confirm with a specific number?

13. How does the fiction story reference this same spread, and how is its treatment different?

Independent Practice

14. Identify one core fact both texts agree on.

15. Why is it important that historical fiction keep core facts like this accurate, even while inventing characters?

Small-Group Work

16. How does the historical account's tone differ from the fiction's tone?

17. What might a reader learn from the fiction story that the historical account does not directly provide?

Small-Group Work

18. What might a reader learn from the historical account that the fiction story does not directly provide?

19. Explain one way the fiction story "uses" history (keeps it accurate) and one way it "alters" or adds to history (invents beyond the record).

Exit Ticket

20. Why is it useful to compare a fictional portrayal of history to a factual account, rather than only reading one or the other?

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. The exact date (February 1, 1960), the four students' real names, and the exact university (North Carolina A&T) — the fiction refers to them only as "four young men" from "the college a few blocks over."
2. To keep the story's focus on the invented character Etta and her personal experience, rather than retelling the documented actions of the real historical figures.
3. Etta, the fifteen-year-old girl who joins the sit-in on the first day.
4. To give readers a relatable, personal perspective on a large historical event — an invented character's private feelings (fear, impulse) can be explored freely, unlike a real historical figure's documented actions.
5. Yes — nearly six months, with the exact date given as July 25, 1960, compared to the February 1 start.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. It does not mention the eventual desegregation date at all; it ends within the same month, with Etta reflecting on the sit-in's early spread to other cities.

7. Ending closer to the story's emotional climax (Etta's decision and its immediate impact) keeps the fiction focused and personal rather than trying to summarize the entire six-month outcome.

8. Roughly three hundred students.

9. It says the four students "returned with more students each morning, filling nearly every stool," giving a general impression of growth without a specific number.

10. No — the historical account does not mention individual families' reactions at all; this is an invented detail added by the fiction to explore a personal, emotional consequence of participating.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. It is a plausible, realistic consequence of the real event that helps readers understand the personal risk and emotional stakes participants likely faced, even if this specific reaction was not documented for a specific person.

12. Sit-ins spread to over fifty cities within two months.

13. Paragraph 7 says "the sit-ins had spread to other cities" by the end of the month, using vaguer language and a shorter, less precise timeframe than the historical account's specific "fifty cities" and "two months."

14. Both agree the sit-in began at a Woolworth's lunch counter, that the original participants were refused service, and that participation grew significantly within days.

15. It maintains the reader's trust that the story reflects a real event honestly, while still allowing room for emotional or personal storytelling through invented details.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. The historical account is factual, objective, and reports events with dates and numbers; the fiction is personal and emotional, focused on Etta's internal feelings, like her shaking hands.

17. A sense of the personal fear, uncertainty, and impulsive decision-making an ordinary participant might have experienced, which the historical account's factual style does not capture.

18. The full scope and outcome of the protest, including exact dates, real participants' names, and its national impact — details the fiction intentionally leaves out or generalizes.

19. Uses: it accurately keeps the location (Woolworth's lunch counter), the real students' initial action, and the pattern of growing participation. Alters: it invents Etta, her personal fear, and her mother's reaction, none of which are part of the documented historical record.

20. Comparing both helps readers understand which parts of a story are verified historical fact and which are the author's invention, giving a fuller, more critical understanding of how history is represented in art.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer